

Williamson on Attitude Reports

Cian Dorr | NYU | Mind and Language Seminar, April 7 2006.

1 Williamson's arguments against contextualism

According to the kind of contextualism I like, attitude reports are context-sensitive, and the resolution of context-sensitivity is often influenced by word choices that don't affect the range of possible readings.

- E.g.: 'Penny believes that gorse has yellow flowers' may suggest a false reading even though 'Penny believes that furze has yellow flowers' suggests a true one.

TW rejects this view. Some of his reasons are general considerations that can be raised against context-sensitivity in many domains; others are specific to this case.

► I won't talk about the general anti-contextualist arguments today, except to flag one general issue: TW is willing to grant context-sensitivity in some cases beyond the most uncontroversial examples of indexicals, such as quantifier domain restriction (Reply to Lederman 19). But the arguments don't seem very discriminating. For example, if it's true that contextualism 'open up myriads of new error-possibilities for speakers who do not carefully store lots of information about the contexts in which they originally acquired linguistically encoded information' (H&O 48), then the fact that we seem to do so well with testimony involving quantifier-domain restriction—acquiring important true beliefs and avoiding false ones—seems quite surprising, given that we don't seem to be particularly more careful about storing such information in those cases.¹

► One specific argument:

- (1) If the truth-conditions of belief ascriptions are normally indifferent to the guise (if any) under which a believer believes a proposition, it seems unlikely that natural languages would have a special semantic mechanism waiting to spring into action just to resolve Frege puzzles and a few related difficulties. (H&O 169)

TW justifies the antecedent by pointing to cases which might plausibly support the conclusion 'the truth-conditions of belief ascriptions are normally *rather uninformative* about the guise under which a believer believes a proposition' (e.g. what words the believer knows, whether the believer is an person or a gorse-panda...). Fine. But what does 'indifferent' even mean? The obvious suggestion is that a normal use of '*S* believes that *P*' expresses a proposition that's true so long as *S* believes that *P* under some guise; but as we'll see, that's not TW's view.

¹Relevant here is the classic psychological finding (Sachs 1967) that we rapidly forget the wording of sentences we hear, while retaining the "gist".

► A second specific argument:

- (2) Someone thinks that I am a physicist
- (3) Considering (2) makes one guise for the proposition that I am a physicist more salient than any other, the sentence 'I am a physicist' itself (or its translation into mentalese, if you prefer). Thus, given a contextualist semantics, one would expect a reading on which only that guise is relevant, so (2) is true if and only if ...*I* think that I am a physicist (under the guise of that very sentence). (Reply to Lederman, 19)

But thinking about contextualist view of quantifier-domain restriction (which TW says he accepts) suggests that even when one thing is uniquely salient, it's often not on the cards to interpret a quantifier as restricted to only that thing. When a bus goes by and I say 'I was once run over by a bus', I'm never going to mean that I was once run over by *that* bus. And when I say 'I uttered a sentence yesterday', I'm not going to mean that I uttered *that* sentence yesterday.

2 Intensionalism

For present purposes, we can equate this with the validity of the argument-form 'Necessarily (*P* iff *Q*); *S* Vs that *P*; therefore *S* Vs that *Q*'.

- The question how to interpret "validity" in such claims raises tricky issues for contextualists (see Dorr 2014). But given invariantism (= rejection of contextualism), we can set these aside.

3 Choice points for invariantist intensionalists about belief

I'm going to assume that Ilists will accept that necessarily, everyone who believes any proposition believes the necessary truth $\top$, since I can't think of any principled story about what circumstances would lead to counterexamples to this generalization.

The more interesting choice points concerns when, if ever, people believe $\perp$. And (more generally) when, if ever, people believe every member of an impossible set of propositions.

3.1 No contradictions

If I had to be an Ilist, I would answer *never* in both cases.

Note that anyone takes this option must say that there are cases where competent English speakers sincerely utter a sentence despite not believing the proposition it expresses—e.g., ‘Some furze is not gorse’. As we might put it, people who produce this sentence are not ‘speaking literally’. This is surprising—after all, the speeches don’t like anything like paradigm cases of nonliteral speech (metaphor, exaggeration, sarcasm...). But (as we’ll see), this surprise is hard for Ilisms to avoid.

- On one kind of view like this, belief obeys the normal modal logic KD. This view scores highly on the score of “simplicity and strength”—factors TW thinks deserve a lot of weight in theorizing in this domain (H&O 202).
- The KD view faces a strong objection from “unawareness” (H&O 224), quite independent of Frege’s puzzle. But there is a weaker “awareness-modified” variant of KD that avoids this objection. I have in mind a (non-normal) logic given by a model theory where, for each world w , there is a set of doxastically accessible worlds R_w and an equivalence relation $\approx_w$, where R_w must be a union of cells of $\approx_w$: $w \in \llbracket B\phi \rrbracket$ iff $\llbracket \phi \rrbracket \subseteq R_w$ and $\llbracket \phi \rrbracket$ is a union of cells in $\approx_w$.²
— This model theory still gives a pretty strong logic, with laws like $B\phi \rightarrow \neg B\neg\phi$ (the D axiom), as well as $B\phi, B\psi \vdash B(\phi \wedge \psi)$, $B\phi, B\psi \vdash B(\phi \vee \psi)$, and $B\phi, B\psi \vdash B(\phi \rightarrow \psi)$.³

The ‘no contradictions’ view raises lots of challenging questions about what’s going on in Frege cases. Does Penny believe that furze has yellow flowers, that it doesn’t, or neither? Does Ralph believe that Ortcutt is a spy, that he isn’t, or neither?

Maybe in some cases, it’s vague! If so, one shouldn’t complain if a theory doesn’t give an answer.

3.2 Rampant contradictions

Right at the other extreme is a kind of view that—given Ilism—leads to the view that it’s extremely common for people to believe contradictory propositions. Roughly:

ASSENT $\Rightarrow$ BELIEF Competent speakers who are disposed to sincerely assent to a sentence they understand believe the proposition it expresses.⁴

- On this view, speakers who follow the usual rules for with ‘or’ and the philosopher’s ‘actually’ and are disposed to assent to at least one false English sentence with which they understand, believe every proposition

²For these models (though without the constraint $u \approx_w v, u \in R_w \Rightarrow v \in R_w$), see Fritz and Lederman 2015.

³Can this logic be axiomatized with just one modal operator B ?

⁴The view I’m interested in is one that combines ASSENT $\Rightarrow$ BELIEF with some non-revisionary accounts of *sincerity*, *competence*, and *understanding*.

expressed by an English sentence they understand. Let P be the false sentence they are disposed to assent to, and Q some other sentence they understand. Then they will be disposed to accept ‘Either actually P , or Q ’, which by intensionalism + S5, expresses the same proposition as Q .⁵

- And those who aren’t disposed to assent to any false English sentences still believe all the propositions expressed by *true* sentences they understand, since when P is true, it expresses the same proposition as ‘ P iff actually P ’, which they are disposed to accept.
- On this view, the truth about belief is *pretty boring*, at least when we are talking about sufficiently sophisticated agents. This seems very bad from the point of view of *strength* (though I suppose it’s good as regards simplicity).

There are passages in that might lead an incautious reader to think that TW endorses something like ASSENT $\Rightarrow$ BELIEF:

- (4) In the case of belief, we may consistently suppose that one believes a proposition p if and only if one believes p under at least one guise; such a guideline was tacitly followed in the discussion of Frege cases above (H&O 213).

But in the reply to Lederman (p.14), it becomes clear that TW does not accept such a view. He points out that ‘A person X s that p if and only if they X that p under some guise’ generates ‘awkward complications’ when X is something like ‘has high/low confidence’, and suggests that ‘Treating graded attitudes as exceptional cases would only make for more complications’.

3.3 Intermediate views

Even setting ASSENT $\Rightarrow$ BELIEF aside, there are two important kinds of cases where TW’s discussion suggests he might accept that agents have contradictory beliefs.

- Agents who are in Frege’s Puzzle cases.
 - For example, one might agree with Quine (1956) that Ralph both believes that Ortcutt is a spy, and believes that Ortcutt is not a spy—or with Salmon and Soames that Ralph believes that Ortcutt is a spy and Ortcutt is not a spy.
- Ordinary agents who, although not themselves identity-confused, are disposed when describing some type-(i) agents to (competently, sincerely) utter sentences whose contents are jointly inconsistent.
 - For example: someone who knows about Penny and is disposed to accept ‘Penny believes that furze has yellow flowers, but does not believe that gorse has yellow flowers’ (as well as ‘Furze = gorse’).

⁵If you don’t think that ‘actually’ works the relevant way in English, replace it with ‘At @’, where ‘@’ is a name introduced by the reference fixing ‘Let @ be the world at which all and only true propositions are true’.

I initially read TW as thinking that contradictory beliefs can arise at least in type (ii) cases and perhaps also in type-(i) cases, though having read the exchange with Lederman, I'm now less sure.

- At H&O 205-6, he asserts (without comment) that 'In some variants of the scenario, Penny believes that furze and gorse are distinct kinds' [note that this would involve believing $\perp$!], and argues that in such a case, 'Penny believes contradictory propositions about her evidence'.
- As regards type (ii) cases: he characterizes his view as being (or requiring) an 'error theory', where this seems to be understood as one that appeals to systematic *false belief* (held by ordinary speakers). The disquotational heuristics in §4.6 are put forth generalizations about how people form *beliefs* about other peoples' attitudes, where pretty often these beliefs are false.
 - In principle, one could think that people who use BDP to form, say, the false belief that Penny doesn't believe that furze is gorse do not simultaneously hold the true belief that Penny does believe that furze is furze; but I see no hint of that thought in the relevant section.

► One way to develop a view where we have contradictory beliefs in type (i) or type (ii) cases would be to endorse something like this:

RESTRICTED ASSENT $\Rightarrow$ BELIEF There are two kinds of sentences, the "transparent" and the "opaque". Competent speakers who are disposed to sincerely assent to a *transparent* sentence they understand believe the proposition it expresses. And the sentences that the contradictory-belief-havers in type (i)/(ii) cases use to express their contradictory beliefs are transparent.

Note that if we think that the class of transparent sentences is closed under 'and' and 'or', then we'll get a version of the "boringness" issue that arises for ASSENT $\Rightarrow$ BELIEF. Those who are disposed to assent to some jointly contradictory transparent sentences $P_1, \dots, P_n$ and follow the usual rules for 'and' and 'or' will also be disposed to assent to $(P_1 \text{ and } \dots \text{ and } P_n)$ or Q , for any Q in their language. So they'll believe every proposition expressed in English by a transparent English sentence they understand. So all these contradiction-believers also believe, e.g., that snow is black. Strength-wise, this doesn't seem like a big improvement on ASSENT $\Rightarrow$ BELIEF.

- Maybe the solution is to give up on closure under 'and' or 'or'? Or to go for some picture very different from RESTRICTED ASSENT $\Rightarrow$ BELIEF? If TW does go for contradictory beliefs in type-(i) or type-(ii) cases, I'm curious what he thinks of this.

► There's a line of argument in Kripke 1979 that I've always found very gripping, that can be used to support the view that people in type (i) cases have contradictory beliefs. Applied to Pierre, the thought is something like this: Pierre's monolingual French friends who just accept 'Londres est jolie' believe that London is pretty, and his monolingual English friends who just accept 'London is not

pretty' believe that London is not pretty. But if the monolingual French friends believe that London is pretty, Pierre does (he didn't lose any beliefs when he moved to London). And if the monolingual English friends believe that London isn't pretty, Pierre does (he wouldn't gain any beliefs if he forgot his old French life). So, Pierre both believes that London is pretty and believes that it isn't.

- If one accepts the conditional premises and rejects the conclusion, one will be led to a view where failures of ASSENT $\Rightarrow$ BELIEF are absolutely pervasive, not just in "Frege-puzzle-related" situation, but in the most routine situations. But the conditional premises are hard to resist.

► An Ilist who thinks that contradictory beliefs are common in type-(ii) cases faces a major explanatory challenge. In general, the beliefs we form by using heuristics are revisable, and can be corrected when they come into conflict with other beliefs. For example, when we have found one apple from a tree to be sour, the 'persistence heuristic' makes us believe that the next apple we try will be sour too; but if we bite into it and find it sweet—or find it to be red, unlike the first apple and like all the other sweet apples we have tried—there's no risk that we end up believing that it's both sour and not sour; we're not *that* thick! Similarly if we come to believe that someone doesn't believe it's raining because they remain silent when we ask 'Is it raining?', but then hear them say 'Yes' when someone else asks, there's not much risk of our just ending up with contradictory beliefs. So if we are sometimes bad at avoiding contradictions that would arise from applying the disquotational heuristics to agents in Frege puzzle cases, that would cry out for some further explanation.⁶

- Those who think contradictory beliefs arise in type-(i) cases have had various interesting ideas about explaining what's special about them, such that even great logical acumen does not block one from ending up with such beliefs. But these ideas do not easily generalize to type-(ii) cases.
- Indeed, there's a significant challenge here for Williamson even if he *doesn't* think we get contradictory beliefs in type-(ii) cases. He does clearly think that in such cases, reliance on the heuristics may (e.g.) lead someone to believe $\perp$ *under the guise of* the sentence 'Penny believes that furze has yellow flowers, and does not believe that gorse has yellow flowers, although furze=gorse'. But whatever the mechanisms are that block us from forming contradictory beliefs whenever heuristics conflict seem also quite effective in blocking us from believing $\perp$ under the guise of sentences that express it—for example, we don't end up believing $\perp$ under the guise of the sentence 'The apple is sweet and the apple is not sweet'. Why don't these mechanisms operate in this case to prevent us from believing $\perp$ under the guise of a logically contradictory sentence?

⁶Braun (1988) does think we are prone to contradictory beliefs in type-(ii) situations, and attempts an explanation in terms of the idea that 'we are intuitive Fregeans'.

3.4 Back to ‘no contradictions’

Let’s return to my favorite version of Ilism, where people—or at least, good classical logicians—do not believe jointly inconsistent propositions. TW seems more open to this than I had thought. But it raises some challenges for the vision developed in the chapter.

► Given a ‘no contradictions’ view, the case for *error theory* (the idea that ordinary people are systematically prone to forming false beliefs about what people in Frege puzzles believe) does not look so strong.

What’s clear given Ilism is that ordinary people are disposed to *assertively utter false sentences* when confronted with Frege cases. For example, they will say both ‘Penny believes that furze has yellow flowers’ and ‘Penny doesn’t believe that gorse has yellow flowers’, and one of these (maybe it’s vague which) is false. But given that they don’t believe both propositions, why on earth would we think that they believe the false one, rather than believing the true one (whichever it is), or believing neither?

But if this is *this* isn’t a case where our ordinary belief-ascription heuristics lead to false belief, why think that we have *any* particular tendency to form false beliefs in such cases (over and above the usual sources of error that everyone accepts)?

► Especially if the idea of pervasive error is dropped, this form of Ilism will have to reckon with a hard *metasemantic* challenge. Suppose—say—that ‘Penny believes that furze has yellow flowers’ expresses a false proposition, but it’s not a proposition that speakers who know about Penny’s situation typically believe. How, then, does that proposition qualify as the one semantically expressed by that sentence?

- Metasemantics is of course very difficult! But it’s still to think that there’s some truth in the vicinity of the criteria of ‘truthfulness and trust’ from Lewis (1975), according to which a sentence’s *semantically expressing* a proposition requires a regularity whereby speakers won’t assert it unless they believe that proposition.
- There are cases where principled stories can be told. For example, some think that ‘flat’ context-insensitively expresses an ultra-demanding property which no physical object instantiates. Here, one could perhaps justify the ascription of that semantic content by reference to its naturalness, or by reference to speaker’s dispositions to back off their assertions when challenged by those who want to insist on a strict standard.
- But neither of these kinds of stories is available in the case of ‘believe’.
- This is related to the concern, raised by Lederman, that TW’s view makes semantics ‘inert’. We say the sentences semantically express certain propositions; but these are not the propositions belief in which gets passed around by sincere utterances of those sentences. On many conceptions of semantics, its explananda are facts about belief and other attitudes and speech acts closely tied to belief. The view we are talking about makes it

hard to see how the facts about what sentences semantically express are related to this.

► Some of TW’s anti-contextualist arguments threaten to carry over to invariantist views of the sort now being considered. On these views, hearing someone assert ‘Penny doesn’t believe that furze is gorse’ does not cause hearers to believe the proposition it expresses, $\perp$. But they do acquire some other beliefs—often true ones—from this, and can pass them on to others by uttering the same sentence themselves. These associated beliefs will presumably vary from one occasion to another. How do they manage this feat without gathering and storing intractable amounts of information about the circumstances of the original utterance?